

The First Transcontinental Railroad

Trace the ripples out from the 1869 golden spike: what caused the railroad, what happened right afterward, and what changed for years to come — for whom.

? Historical challenge

On May 10, 1869, two railroads met at Promontory Summit, Utah, and a golden spike joined the coasts by rail for the first time. A trip that once took months now took about a week. But every big change sends out ripples. What caused the railroad, what happened right afterward, and what changed later — and who was helped or hurt?

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Pacific Railway Act (1862) – National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The 1862 law, signed by Lincoln, that funded the railroad with federal land and loans.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did the government give the railroad companies?
- Why would the government help pay for a railroad?

SOURCES 2

The Archeology of Chinese Laborers Who Connected the Country (National Park Service)

SECONDARY SOURCE

How over 12,000 Chinese immigrant laborers built the Central Pacific line.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Who did much of the hardest building work?
- Why might their story have been left out for so long?

SOURCES 3

Transcontinental Railroad – Railroads (Library of Congress)

SECONDARY SOURCE

Background and sources on how the two lines met at Promontory Summit.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Where and when did the two lines meet?
- What changed about travel afterward?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

WHAT CHANGED LATER?

Four dashed rectangular boxes for notes.

WHAT HAPPENED RIGHT AFTERWARD?

Four dashed rectangular boxes for notes.

WHAT CAUSED IT?

Four dashed rectangular boxes for notes.

THE EVENT

The Golden Spike – the railroad joins the coasts

May 10, 1869

Promontory Summit, Utah

People / groups affected

The railroad companies — Central Pacific and Union Pacific

Immigrant laborers — Chinese (Central Pacific) and Irish (Union Pacific)

Native nations of the Plains and West

Settlers, farmers, and traders moving into the West

Which result mattered most?

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Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your ripples with a partner. Which effects did you both list? Which did only one of you find?
- Did you put any effect in a different ring (immediate vs. later) than your partner? Talk about why.

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Choose the one result of the railroad you think mattered most. Use evidence from your ripples to explain who it helped and who it hurt.